infantry were slaughtered, and the headless corpses danced in a frenzy on the bloody battlefields'.[10] The duo then founded the Maurya Empire, c. 321 BCE. These were early days for both the Seleucid and Maurya empires. After skirmishes in the north-west in which the Mauryans gained control over the Indus Plains, both emperors saw wisdom in concluding a peace treaty (303 BCE). Seleucus apparently married his daughter to Chandragupta and received 500 elephants, inaugurating a long era of neighbourly trade relations.

Alexander's cultural impact, however, was larger than his political impact, and it went both ways. The accounts of his literate generals, like admiral Nearchus's, helped demystify India to fellow Greeks at home (though their taste for bizarre exotica remained). At least two Greek philosophers, Pyrrho of Elis and Anaxarchus, had travelled with Alexander and met the gymnosophists. Henceforth, atop an earlier trickle, 'Indian ideas entered the Hellenistic and Mediterranean world' more steadily, influencing many schools of thought in Greece and Rome, such as Pyrrhonism, Stoicism and Neoplatonism.[11]

A few decades later, Ashoka, Chandragupta's grandson and heir to the Mauryan Empire, embraced Buddhism and sent out missionaries across Asia, including to Afghanistan and Central Asia. One of his rock edicts in Khandahar was inscribed in Greek. Buddhism spread rapidly in these parts and across India. A century later, Menander (aka Milinda), a Greek-origin king in the subcontinent's north-west, even embraced Buddhism, apparently following a discussion with the sage Nagasena (their dialogue appears in the Pali text *Milind Panha*).

The Greek substrate of the Seleucid Empire also influenced Indian culture, as neighbours often do, notably through the sublime Gandhara style of Buddhist art. Greek astronomical ideas strongly influenced Indian astronomy.[12] In early Sanskrit texts, the Greeks appear as 'Yavana', a term later used for all foreigners from the west of India. As Keay writes, Alexander had effectively 'prised open a window on the East through which emissaries would pass, ideas would shine, and prying eyes would covet'.[13] One such emissary was the Greek Megasthenes, sent by Seleucus to Chandragupta's court, c. 300 BCE.